

# 1. The Four Vedas

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## Background

- Originally Vedas were three (Trayi Vidya): Rig, Yajur, Sama. Atharva was added later.
- Vyasa (Krishna Dvaipayana) organized the Vedic corpus into 4 divisions and assigned each to a disciple: Paila (Rigveda), Vaishampayana (Yajurveda), Jaimini (Samaveda), Sumantu (Atharvaveda).

## 1.1 Rigveda

- Oldest and largest of the four Vedas — main repository of classical Sanskrit poetry.
- Contains origins of religious and philosophical development of ancient Indian society.
- Verses (Rks) are hymns addressed to deities; priest is called Hotr.
- Promotes unity in diversity: 'truth is one but learned ones articulate it differently' (ekam sat viprah bahuda vadanti, RV1.164.46).
- Notable suktas: Nasadiya-sukta (RV10.129) — origin of universe; Hiranyagarbha-sukta (RV10.121); Purusa-sukta (RV10.90).

## 1.2 Yajurveda

- Derived from root Yaj — worship associated with sacrifice. Focuses entirely on Yajna (sacrifice).
- Mantras (called yajus) are mostly in prose form; guidebook for the Adhvaryu priest.
- Covers: human anatomy, metals, constellations, seasons, numbers, geometry, grains, yogic insights.
- Divided into two branches:
  - Krishna (Black) Yajurveda — more ancient.
  - Shukla (White) Yajurveda — composed by Yajnavalkya after a dispute with his guru.

## 1.3 Samaveda

- Derived from 'Sama' — to please, pacify or satisfy. Essentially Rigveda mantras set to music.
- Mantras called 'Sama'; sung at sacrifices to please deities after offerings.
- Total 1,875 mantras; only 75 are unique — rest taken from Rigveda.
- Three branches: Kauthuma, Ranayaniya, Jaiminiya. (Earlier had 1000 branches.)
- Origin of Indian classical music lies in the Samaveda (mantras set to seven musical scales).

## 1.4 Atharvaveda

- Later addition to the original three Vedas. Deals more with worldly 'here and now' than 'hereafter'.
- Priest is Brahman — oversees overall coordination and quality control of the ritual.
- 20 kandas, 736 suktas, 6,077 mantras. Two surviving branches: Paippalada and Shaunakiya.
- Unique features: deals with diseases and cures, prolonging life, building construction, trade, statecraft.

- Prayers for prosperity include all living beings (2-legged, 4-legged, even 8 and 9-legged creatures).

## 2. Four Divisions of Each Veda

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- Each Veda is divided into 4 portions: Samhita, Brahmana, Aranyaka, Upanishad.

### 2.1 Samhita (Mantra Portion)

- Main portion of each Veda — collection of mantras/hymns in praise of deities.
- Rigveda-samhita: 10,552 mantras. Each sukta identifies the rishi, devata, and metre.
- 400+ rishis; 14 categories of devatas. About 25 women rishis composed hymns in Rigveda.
- Key deities: Indra (1/3 of mantras), Agni (1/4 of mantras), Varuna, Mitra.

### 2.2 Brahmanas

- Collection of knowledge on rituals and rites — written in prose. Large portion of Vedic repository.
- Describe different types of yajnas, explanatory notes on mantras, reasons for rituals.
- Examples: Aitareya-brahmana (Soma sacrifice), Kausitaki-brahmana (food sacrifice, full-moon), Shatapatha-brahmana (Agnicayana, Asvamedha-yajna).
- Samaveda has the largest collection of 8 Brahmanas; Atharvaveda has Gopatha Brahmana.

### 2.3 Aranyakas

- Third portion — content similar to Brahmanas but takes a philosophical approach to yajnas.
- Explains symbolism and philosophical aspects of rituals. Daily activities like breathing and eating are also given deep meaning.
- Called 'Aranyaka' (forest texts) — meant to be learned in secluded forest areas.
- Bridge between Brahmanas and Upanishads. 6 Aranyakas exist — none associated with Atharvaveda.

### 2.4 Upanishads

- Highest philosophical content of the Vedas — 'sitting near a Guru to receive wisdom.'
- Focus on knowledge of Brahman (ultimate reality), Atman, and Maha-vakyas (ultimate truths).
- Three aspects studied: Jiva (living being), Jagat (Universe), Ishvara (all-encompassing force).
- Originally 1,180 Upanishads; currently about 200 located. 10 are considered principal.
- Indian emblem motto 'Satyam Eva Jayate' is from the Mundaka-upanishad.

## 3. Vedangas — Six Limbs of the Vedas

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- As language evolved, people needed tools to read and understand Vedic texts correctly.
- Six complementary disciplines were created — called Vedangas ('limbs of the Vedas').
- Six Vedangas: Siksa, Vyakarana, Nirukta, Chandas, Kalpa, Jyotisa.

### 3.1 Siksa (Phonetics)

- Science of pronunciation — first thing taught in ancient education.
- Preserves Vedic texts from corruption; defines characteristics of basic sound units (varna).
- Explains how sound (nada) is generated through air, space, tongue, and articulation points.
- Most popular work: Paniniya-siksa, attributed to grammarian Panini.

### 3.2 Vyakarana (Grammar)

- Sanskrit grammar — rules to construct and analyze words unambiguously.
- Panini's Ashtadhyayi is the most famous work; nearly 4000 sutras.
- Allows both generating new words AND reverse-engineering existing words.
- Highly logical — similar to modern data processing, recursive logic, algorithmic thinking.
- Patanjali's Maha-bhasya is a commentary on Ashtadhyayi that firmly established Panini's work.

### 3.3 Nirukta (Etymology)

- Extracts meaning of words using linguistic theories and phonetic changes.
- Different from Vyakarana: Vyakarana constructs correct word forms; Nirukta analyses word meanings.
- Yaska wrote Nirukta (5th century BCE) — commentary on Nighantu (collection of rare Vedic words).
- Nighantu = thesaurus with synonyms. Nighantu has 1,770 words in 3 parts (Naighantu, Naigama, Daivata).
- Four-step approach: observe repeated letters, observe repeated meanings, map sounds to meanings, assign meaning to word components.
- Considered the most ancient work on etymology anywhere in the world.

### 3.4 Chandas (Metre/Prosody)

- Study of metres used in Vedic mantras. Chandas = metre of poetic composition.
- Hierarchy: Syllables (aksara) → Padas (quarter) → Metre (chandas).
- Any addition or removal of even one syllable disrupts the rhythm — making corruption immediately detectable.
- Major treatise: Chandah-sastra by Pingala (c. 300 BCE).

#### Seven Main Vedic Metres:

| Metre   | No. of Padas | Syllables      |
|---------|--------------|----------------|
| Gayatri | 3            | 8+8+8 = 24     |
| Ushnih  | 3            | 8+8+12 = 28    |
| Anustup | 4            | 8+8+8+8 = 32   |
| Brhati  | 4            | 8+8+12+8 = 36  |
| Pankti  | 5            | 8+8+8+8+8 = 40 |

|         |   |                    |
|---------|---|--------------------|
| Tristup | 4 | $11+11+11+11 = 44$ |
| Jagati  | 4 | $12+12+12+12 = 48$ |

### 3.5 Kalpa (Ritual Manual)

- A user manual providing instructions for all aspects of Vedic life — personal, family, social.
- Four types of Kalpa-sutras:
  - Srauta-sutras — Guide for conducting Vedic rituals (Agnihotra, Somayaga, Asvamedha, etc.)
  - Sulba-sutras — Rules for measurement and construction of fire altars and sacrificial spaces.
  - Grhya-sutras — Guide for household ceremonies (16 samskaras from birth to death).
  - Dharma-sutras — Guide for social duties; rules of conduct, governance, taxation, army.
- Sulba-sutras note: require precise geometry — this is why ancient Indians developed accurate approximation of  $\pi$  ( $\pi$ ) and  $\sqrt{2}$ .

### 3.6 Jyotisa (Astronomy/Astrology)

- Knowledge of movement of stars and planetary bodies; basis for the natural calendar.
- Lunar and solar cycles play a crucial role in cultural and spiritual life — all festivals are linked to them.
- Jyotisa is classified into: Vaidika (connected to Vedas) and Laukika (worldly).
- Vedanga-jyotisa: Rgvedic version — 36 verses; Yajurvedic version — 43 verses.
- Jyotisa-sastra is divided into three parts:
  - Siddhanta: Planetary theory, time measures, algebraic computations, star positions.
  - Samhita: Astrology — planetary movements, earthquakes, architecture (Vastu), omens, water springs.
  - Hora: Horoscopes, nimitta (omens), lagna calculation, aspects of human life.